

Foot Anstey

Complete firm and application research — history, values, responsible business, sector expertise, recent deals, culture, apprenticeship structure and application guidance.

- Growth model:** Organic growth — high street to national, not merger-driven
- Practice areas:** Real estate, corporate, commercial, wills & probate (no criminal)
- Presence:** Growing new Manchester office alongside existing base
- Apprenticeship:** 5-year programme with staged qualification routes (CILEX or SQE)

1. Firm Overview & History	—
2. Values	—
3. Culture	—
4. Responsible Business Strategy	—
5. Community & Partnerships	—
6. Awards & Recognition	—
7. Legal Tech	—
8. Sectors — Retail & Consumer	—
9. Sectors — Governance	—
10. Recent Deals & Examples	—
11. Apprenticeship Programme	—
12. Application Tips (From the Firm)	—
13. Personal Fit Notes	—
14. Sources & Further Reading	—

1. Firm Overview & History

- Grew organically from a high-street practice to a national firm — not through merger
- Growing presence in a new Manchester office, alongside its established base
- Full-service in most respects: real estate, corporate, commercial, wills and probate — but does not practise criminal law
- Ambitious — fast-growing, with a serious strategy behind its expansion
- Works via a sector approach: seven sectors work together to serve client needs with a deep understanding of the challenges and opportunities each faces
- Has maintained a strong, consistent focus on cultural identity and client focus throughout its growth
- Provides expert advice that is easily integrated and actionable in the client's world

2. Values

The firm's stated aim is to become its clients' most trusted adviser — an enabler of client ambition. How it works is treated as being just as important as what it does.

Passionately responsible

Committed to making a real difference for people, clients, communities and the planet.

Boldly entrepreneurial

Challenges convention, embraces innovation, and creates space for every voice to contribute ideas and shape solutions.

Refreshingly human

Puts people first — whether working with colleagues or clients, taking time to listen and build trust, creating a culture where people thrive and clients feel supported.

Seriously ambitious

Sets the bar high and keeps raising it — holding itself to the highest standards and taking pride in work that drives real impact.

Purposefully collaborative

Believes the best outcomes come from working together — sharing ideas, supporting each other, and realising goals as one team.

3. Culture

- Described as "refreshingly human" — draws people in through a genuine network and sense of fit and contribution to the culture
- Entrepreneurial even in small ideas — e.g. a "space law" practice area idea originated from a partner
- Employee-driven creation/consultation groups contribute to shaping firm ideas
- Rewarding employee experience with heavy investment in people, including a parental support package (covering paid reproductive health products via Fertifa) and flexible working
- Uses a Culturescope assessment (from ipsychtech), applying behavioural science to shape culture aligned with the growth strategy

4. Responsible Business Strategy

- Responsible business is framed as helping to reduce business risk, attract talent, and build relationships in support of sustainable growth
- Invests at least 1% of net profit into the responsible business programme
- Organised around five impact areas via a materiality matrix and action plan: **Business, Clients, Environment, Community, People**
- **Business** — benchmarking and ensuring policies meet the highest standards
- **Clients** — building relationships around shared values with like-minded clients
- **Environment** — targeting net zero and zero landfill, with stretching targets and efficiency education for staff
- **Community** — long-term strategic partnerships rather than one-off, token work

A Responsible Business Impact Report was unveiled in February 2026, highlighting progress on ESG and community goals.

The foundations we've laid this year are just the beginning, and I look forward to seeing the positive impact we will create in the years ahead.
— Firm statement

5. Community & Partnerships

Young Enterprise partnership

A three-year partnership to equip young people with work skills and unlock potential for social mobility — improving enterprise skills in disadvantaged schools and engaging employees to provide real experience.

- 81% of young people have already taken part in entrepreneurial activity
- Only 4% say they have no interest at all in being entrepreneurial

- 71% believe entrepreneurs are vital to the UK's economic future
- 76% feel that being enterprising boosts a young person's social mobility

Barriers young people cite: lack of money or savings (46%), fear of failure (40%), fear of financial insecurity (34%), and limited access to networks or mentors (15%). Foot Anstey's partnership with Young Enterprise aims to address some of these barriers — particularly access to networks, role models and enterprise experience.

Other community work

- Youth Hostels Association — over £50,000 donated, enabling 310 individuals to benefit from trips that build confidence and growth
- The Foot Anstey Foundation supports fundraising efforts and local charities, including support for families and childhood poverty
- A double materiality assessment helps identify ESG issues affected by the firm's operations

6. Awards & Recognition

- Ranked **Tier 1** in 10 practice areas, reflecting strength in delivering clear, commercially focused advice across priority sectors
- Growing in family law (moving from Tier 3 to Tier 2)
- **Diversity & Inclusion Award** — Bristol Legal Awards 2025, for its Achieve programme
- Top 75 Employer — Social Mobility Employer Index 2025
- Recognised for a strong, growing responsible business programme

7. Legal Tech

- Uses legal tech including **BigHand Quantum** and **Evaluate** to improve pricing, profitability and productivity — a data-driven management approach
- The tech team notes that the pace of new technology development is exponential, making it genuinely challenging just to maintain standards — with an in-depth understanding of how tech law can be leveraged for efficiency and opportunity
- **BreachReady** — launched jointly with cyber security specialists (Integrity360) and communications firm Rostrum, providing businesses with an integrated solution for data protection and breach readiness. Motivated by nearly 50% of businesses experiencing a breach in the past year, and increasingly sophisticated, targeted attacks. Crisis communication is framed as essential to maintaining stakeholder trust; the service audits breach preparedness against best-practice standards to mitigate risk

8. Sectors — Retail & Consumer

One of the firm's core sectors, bringing in additional experts to improve client service. Award-winning for progressive solutions and sector knowledge across property, commercial agreements, data protection, brand collaborations, harassment, and sports and events — with a goal of keeping businesses compliant and competitive.

Brand collaborations

Foot Anstey conducted its own study of 80 companies (including Harrods, eBay, M&S and Deliveroo): 93% of collaborations were found to be successful, giving both parties access to resources, cost savings and market share — though 69% reported legal barriers (e.g. contract breach risk), with benefits still outweighing the risks. Due diligence is needed to ensure values align and to avoid hidden issues (e.g. a co-op partnership that undermined a brand's image).

2025/26 sector trends

- **Product safety:** 2025 saw increased scrutiny of product safety, ethical standards and workforce governance — showing how quickly reputational concerns can become legal/financial impacts. An investigation found roughly 800 items for sale on platforms like Amazon, eBay and AliExpress matched previously flagged dangerous products, raising retailer liability risk; the Product Regulation and Metrology Act (July 2025) lets the Secretary of State impose safety requirements via delegated legislation
- **Greenwashing:** retailers including Nike, Superdry and Lacoste made misleading claims without evidence (62% of claims examined were misleading); the CMA can now fine retailers up to 10% of annual turnover for this since April 2025, requiring adherence to the Green Claims Code with internal verification checks
- **Labour standards:** unethical labour practices aren't always identified in first audits — more due diligence and stronger supplier mapping is needed; pay models (e.g. piece-rate/pay-per-parcel structures) have been found to fall below minimum wage once costs like fuel are accounted for, leading to unintentional breaches
- **Retail crime & tech:** shoplifting rose ~20% in a year, with 70% of retail workers experiencing verbal abuse and 18% assaulted; retailers are turning to body cams, facial recognition technology (FRT) and fortified kiosks (e.g. Facewatch, adopted by Sainsbury's, Flannels, Sports Direct) — reportedly limiting rises in incidents to ~1.4% versus an unmitigated 44% rise, though this raises data privacy and "function creep" concerns that must be handled transparently
- **Advertising restrictions:** from January 2026, paid online advertising for less healthy food/drink (HFSS) products is prohibited, alongside a 9pm TV watershed
- **Pricing transparency:** new guidance from April 2026 on pricing transparency online and in-store, for comparability
- **IP:** ongoing activity in counterfeit and lookalike products; brand owners are taking action against supermarkets and high-profile designers on trade mark infringement, with new EU measures supporting brand owners

- **AI regulation:** the EU AI Act aims to improve the internal market, promote trustworthy AI, and guard against harmful AI effects; firms may need AI audits, especially for high-risk systems; penalties can reach 1.5–7% of annual turnover
- **Collective actions:** a continuing rise in collective actions before the Competition Appeals Tribunal (CAT), driven by the 2020 *Merricks v Mastercard* Supreme Court ruling and growing third-party litigation funding — putting large, dominant businesses (especially tech and finance) at risk of significant damages claims; the first environmental collective action (against Severn Trent Water) may signal further environmental-law cases to come
- **Budget changes:** increased dividend tax rates from April 2026 (affecting small business owners/dividend-reliant investors); expansion of the Enterprise Management Incentive scheme; a new 40% first-year capital allowance from January 2026 alongside reduced writing-down allowances; a three-year stamp duty/SDRT exemption for new London Stock Exchange listings, aimed at reviving UK listings
- **Supply chain automation:** continued focus on IoT, AI and smart assets (e.g. shipment-tracking devices reporting via blockchain) across supply chains, alongside wider generative AI rollout
- **DMCCA 2024 changes (from 6 April 2025):** prohibition of drip-pricing (total price must be shown upfront); new proactive obligations on retailers to prevent and remove fake/concealed incentivised reviews; new CMA enforcement powers, including monetary penalties on businesses and senior individuals
- **Lookalike packaging:** the Supreme Court upheld the Court of Appeal's decision in *Thatchers Cider Company Limited v Aldi Stores Limited*, reinforcing that brand owners can succeed on unfair advantage claims where competitors' packaging comes too close to distinctive designs — highlighting the value of registering packaging as trade marks/design rights
- **Online marketplaces:** a surge in infringement actions against fast-growing e-commerce platforms (e.g. claims against Temu-style operators over counterfeit/clone products); courts have reinforced that platforms targeting UK consumers can be liable, following *Lifestyle Equities v Amazon* — brand owners are encouraged to monitor marketplaces and pursue proactive takedown strategies

9. Sectors — Governance

Corporate law is entering a period of notable change, requiring companies to prioritise transparency, manage increasing administrative burdens, and adapt to evolving societal expectations — including updates to the Economic Crime and Corporate Transparency Bill, changes to Payment Practices Reporting Regulations, and growing ESG obligations, all pointing to a wider effort to foster ethical business practices.

IP & brand context (wider notes)

Ongoing lookalike/counterfeit product activity continues, with brand owners taking action against supermarkets and designers. As the UK continues its departure from EU law (following the Retained EU Law (Revocation and Reform) Act 2023), the upcoming cloned trade marks deadline (end of 2025) is a key milestone for rights holders. Canada implemented major trade mark law amendments in April 2025 (registrar-initiated cancellation for non-use, proof-of-use requirements, cost awards against bad-faith filings). In the EU, late-2025 Digital Omnibus proposals aim to streamline compliance under the AI Act, GDPR and Data Act, extending deadlines for high-risk AI systems to late 2027 or beyond.

10. Recent Deals & Examples

- Advised on an investment round for **TRUSS**, an AI-powered sustainable fashion start-up, through FIGR Ventures
- Advised sustainable underwear brand **Stripe & Stare** on a £2.5m investment from BGF (2022) — illustrative of work with growth consumer brands
- Strengthened retail & consumer capability by hiring a former general counsel from listed online retailer Boohoo, enhancing capacity to advise on retail regulatory, ESG and commercial deals

The pace of change is relentless, but that's exactly what makes it such an exciting space to be in as a lawyer. I'm delighted to join a firm that is growing as rapidly as its clients.

— Firm/team member statement

The firm also publicises its own studies and analysis to support clients and the public — including a publicly available report on how to approach brand collaborations, and free webinars offering commercial market insight in one place.

11. Apprenticeship Programme

- Five-year programme with early exposure to real work
- Support structure: a mentor, dedicated supervisor, supportive buddy, and Early Careers (EC) guidance
- Before starting: a comprehensive induction and skills masterclass, plus introductions to the Early Careers team, supervisor and buddy

Programme stages

- **Stages 1-2:** Paralegal apprenticeship — working with the managed legal services team to build business and professional skills; drives quality, efficiency and cross-team collaboration; fast-paced with a wide variety of work; includes a summer boot camp for a small cohort (around 4 individuals), designed to set apprentices up for success. Apprentices choose their qualification route: **CILEX** or **SQE**
- **Stage 3:** Study toward qualification, with broader area experience, working within one legal team
- **Stages 4-6:** Equivalent to the training contract stage

Academic requirement referenced: BBB at A Level (or equivalent commitment). A partner supervisor provides both life and technical advice throughout.

Extra perk: an additional day off on your birthday.

12. Application Tips (From the Firm)

- Make sure the opportunity aligns with your career goals and ambitions — explore the firm's website, listen to "The Trainee Lowdown" podcast series, and watch the "Step into Foot Anstey: Apprenticeship Special" webinar recording
- The application form is a chance to show what sets you apart — beyond legal experience and business understanding, the firm wants to find out more about **you** as a person
- For guidance on strong applications: watch the firm's application guidance webinar recording, or listen to Episode 2 of The Trainee Lowdown podcast

Interview format notes

- Online assessment and video interview, followed by a final-stage interview
- A two-week window is typically given to complete the video interview; questions can be done separately rather than all at once
- Preparation time is roughly 1 minute per question (notes allowed), followed by a 1-minute answer
- Use **PEEL** (Point, Evidence, Explain, Link) for contextual/motivation questions, and **STAR** (Situation, Task, Action, Result) for competency questions
- Show personality and talk about yourself — the assessors are genuinely interested; still keep answers structured and clearly linked to the specifics of the role

13. Personal Fit Notes

- The firm's "refreshingly human" culture and existing personal network make it feel like a strong fit, with a genuine sense that you'd add to (not just join) the culture
- An apprenticeship route allows building a career much earlier, and investing in that future sooner rather than later
- Application tips webinar differentiators: the firm's full-service (bar criminal) offering, organic growth story, and sector-based approach are all worth referencing directly when explaining firm-specific interest
- The entrepreneurial culture (e.g. the space law idea originating from a partner) — and things like podcast content — is genuinely appealing and worth mentioning as a cultural fit point

14. Sources & Further Reading

- footanstey.com/our-insights — "How to use AI authentically when applying to law firms"
- footanstey.com/our-insights — "Apprenticeships in Action: our apprentices share their journeys"
- footanstey.com/our-insights — "Apprentice to Expert: Ollie's journey with Foot Anstey"
- footanstey.com/our-insights — "Watch now: Apprenticeship Special — Step into Foot Anstey"
- footanstey.com/our-insights — "Meet Freya Coombs" / "Freya shares her apprenticeship experience"
- footanstey.com/sectors/private-equity/recent-corporate-deals — recent deals list
- Foot Anstey Materiality Assessment 2024 (PDF, footanstey.com)
- Foot Anstey / BigHand digital case study — legalsupportnetwork.co.uk

Sources: footanstey.com sector, insight and careers pages; firm press releases and reports (2025/26); Bristol Legal Awards; Social Mobility Employer Index. Compiled as private research — verify current salary, deadline and programme details against the live listing before applying.